

Benchmark Social Justice Action Plan

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It is a novel idea to me that social justice (the idea that inequity based on skin color, race, sexual preference, gender, or socio-economic status exists and needs to be eradicated) must be accounted for in this world. I grew up in a predominantly white, primarily financial, food, and shelter-secure culture/environment/geographic location. The few people of color in my school were friends like any other until High School, or so I thought. I often ask myself where those people are. And unfortunately, I can't answer that question. Frankly, I can't tell you where many people I grew up with are, but the people of color seemed to have disappeared after High School. Those who were different than me in other ways were not treated with respect in hindsight. They were asked to conceal themselves, which gave me the perspective that they were okay; they didn't need me to advocate for them. If I were to go back and see how they perceived the mandate to conceal their differences, would I do anything differently?

Existential Questions

The better question is, do I do anything different now? Do I see people being mistreated based on their differences from the majority or their differences from the social/cultural norm and respond? I say respond, period, because in the past, I have not responded at all. Does it matter? Does it matter that I see the oppression or judgment and act? Does my voice make a difference in the grand scheme of the world? To my clients who are different from me and whom I have been able to treat through a social justice lens, yes, it matters. Have I always? No. I remember one international student who did not speak English well, was not a believer in Jesus, and was struggling with grief and being alone. I did not give her the compassionate treatment I would be proud of. Why? Because it would take a lot of work to see the world through her eyes, and I didn't want to do so at the time. However, (and this doesn't make up for that client, but) I

have learned from that, and I currently have several clients who look, believe, or prefer differently than me and the social/cultural norm of my area. I am learning from this exercise how to frame a social justice compass for myself (Lee, 2007).

Privilege

And I must. For, whether my brothers in Christ see eye to eye with me on this or not, I have many privileges. I mention my brothers in Christ here because I have felt the most pushback on that word from people who would say they are the same as me. I have not always fought them on the semantics, but I have tried to utilize grace and kindness to show them how we, white, middle-class (some would say affluent), educated men, enjoy a tremendous amount of freedom to do as we please and say what we please just because of those things. Is this fair to point out to us? Maybe not. Maybe it's not okay when we are being shamed for it while trying to minimize it. But it is fair when we are not admitting, becoming aware, and using said privilege to speak up for change. I am most aware of my privilege when I see the inequality between men and women in the Church (and the southern workplace that treats work like the church, for that matter). I aim to research and write my dissertation on some form of advocacy for this disparity.

Oppression

Although most of my life has been lived with the benefit of privilege, I remember one time when I felt oppressed for my choices. My wife and I started our relationship early. We met in junior high school and dated again immediately after graduating High School. We were young and looking to distance ourselves from the legalistic upbringing that we had experienced. We made some terrible decisions that culminated in the worst decision of our lives: an abortion. One fateful night a few years after returning to church and a morally determinative lifestyle, I attended a meeting for people advocating for abortion alternatives. Upon relating my story to the

group, I was met with one elderly gentleman calling me a pharisee and declaring, “Pharisees don’t attend meetings.” Needless to say, I never returned to that meeting or any other meeting where I could be called out for my poor and despicable choices in such a manner. Only years later, after feeling safe at Celebrate Recovery, have I confessed this sin to others again, this time with healing. I believe this experience gave me the eyes to see those oppressed and, at the very least, not contribute to the oppression. Yet, saying that, I recall Martin Luther King Jr. stating that one who stays quiet about oppression is just as guilty of the sin. My contribution to oppression then has been in early life, as I mentioned, and in later life: silence.

Multicultural Humility

Silence is my way of denying there is a problem. Denying there is a difference. Deny someone else might be hurt, offended, triggered, or minimized by something I see as tradition, culture, or expected. I have been blessed with children who are not silent. My oldest married a woman whose family practiced South Korean culture, including speaking the language in the home where she grew up. My youngest married a man whose family is still intensely proud of their Mexican traditions and culture. I get emotional thinking about the way they welcome these people into our home! I ate Tamales and a custard pie like none I have ever had on Easter with my son-in-law’s family. I ate Kimchee and Korean BBQ Pork shoulder for Christmas with my daughter-in-law. I have never been so culturally diverse in my life, and I love it. But I have a long way to go to understand what my 30-year-old black male client means when he says he might have to move home to care for his family. I have a long way to go to make sense of what my 26-year-old white homosexual male client means when he says he is not safe with men. I have a long way to go in helping my 29-year-old white female client overcome traumatic sexual abuse when she was eight from her adopted brother, who suddenly died three years ago. Staying

aware that my experience is far from these people's experience is my most basic skill in multicultural competency.

Social Justice Compass

However, as Lewis et al. (2018) and Lee (2007) argue, I need to have a compass for my competency, advocacy, education, and voice. When I read that back to myself, I hear the word intentionality. How am I going to be intentional with my voice? If my privilege buys me anything, may it be freedom for those who have no voice, healing for those who have no access, acceptance for those pushed outside, and dignity for those who are struggling to be human. Reflecting on the many questions and points of concern in the Lewis et al. (2018) compilation, I find the most helpful aspect to be the diagram of domains. This diagram could help me stay aware and stay focused on the needs and views of others. In the same vein, it can be overwhelming. There are a lot of domains and facets to remain aware of. However, being divided into client, social, and public settings helps me see that I do not have to be all things to all people at all times. I simply need to be aware of who is present with me and cognizant of how to attune to them.

From elementary school to being a 51-year-old Ph.D. student, it is not all that different. I can still be very naïve and shelter myself from the reality of our stratified world. I may know more about myself and how humans work and trust God more. But I can easily ignore the pain in this world, which I do not want to see. Someone told me about twenty years ago that the average white man in America never *had* to socialize with a black man if he didn't want to. My question then was, "Is that true?". My question now is, "Why wouldn't I want to?".

References

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